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WOUNDS OF THE PAST: Feminine Histories and Silent Landscapes in *Ice-Candy-Man* and *What the Body Remembers*

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WOUNDS OF THE PAST: Feminine Histories and Silent Landscapes in *Ice-Candy-Man* and *What the Body Remembers*

_____Kazemi Afrose

Abstract

*This paper will attempt to investigate the unique power of Partition Literature to illuminate the deep and lasting effects of the 1947 Partition of India on individuals and societies. Through an analysis of recurring themes such as displacement, trauma, fractured identity, and the role of memory and gender, this study aims to highlight how authors have captured both personal and collective struggles. By weaving together stories of survival, resilience, and lost homes, Partition Literature offers a window into the enduring scars left by Partition, shaping how contemporary identities and histories continue to evolve in South Asia. This paper examines *Ice-Candy-Man* by Bapsi Sidhwa and *What the Body Remembers* by Shauna Singh Baldwin focusing on their portrayal of women's experiences during the Partition of India. These novels foreground gendered violence, displacement, and resilience, offering alternative histories that challenge dominant political narratives. Additionally, this paper delves into the symbolic role of landscapes as witnesses to human suffering, linking trauma and memory to physical spaces. The study argues that both works intertwine personal and collective identities with a feminist critique of Partition's social and political aftermath.*

Keywords: Partition Literature, 1947 Partition, Displacement, Trauma, Gendered experiences, Communal violence, etc.

Introduction

In 1947, the Indian subcontinent was torn asunder, dividing a land rich with shared histories, languages, and communities into two newly forged nations: India and Pakistan. This was no mere politics act – it was a visceral tearing that forced millions to confront questions of belonging, identity, and faith. While it is often framed in terms of political negotiations and religious divisions its effect on individuals, particularly women, are often side-lined. Postcolonial Feminist literature on partition seeks to address these silences, presenting women's narratives as central to understanding the deeper impacts of the event. This theoretical paradigm challenges how women's experiences are marginalized in prevailing historical narratives, particularly in settings influenced by nationalism, colonialism, and cultural change. Feminist approaches to Partition draw from postcolonial feminist theorists like Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, who discuss the erasure of marginalized voices, especially women, in the construction of dominant historical discourses (Spivak 271).

Bapsi Sidhwa's *Ice- Candy-Man* and Shauna Singh Baldwin's *What the Body Remembers* are two significant works that illuminate women's experiences during Partition. *Ice-Candy-Man* uses the perspective of a young Parsi girl, Lenny, to recount the personal and communal tragedies of Lahore, while *What the Body Remembers* focuses on Roop and Satya, two Sikh women navigating the patriarchal structures of their time against the backdrop of Partition. Lenny's perspective on communal violence – "The killing begins casually, unexpectedly, like a summer storm." (Baldwin 98) This line, viewed from Lenny's naive yet perceptive viewpoint, demonstrates how partition violence breaks out abruptly, upsetting lives and communities. Lenny's story,

mediated through a child's innocence and perplexity, depicts the horrors taking place in Lahore and Roop's struggle within patriarchy in *What the Body Remembers* when she states – "Daughters are only wells to be dug, waiting for a man's seed. Their purpose is to give sons." (citation) This statement highlights the pervasive patriarchy in Roop's society, where women's worth is largely defined by their ability to bear children. Roop's experiences, shaped by these societal norms, reflect the broader struggles of women as they confront gender-based oppression during the Partition era.

This paper compares these novels, examining how they portray gendered violence, agency, and memory while situating these themes within the broader cultural and ecological landscapes of Partition.

I. Gendered Violence and the Body as a Battleground

Both novels emphasize the horrific violence that women endured during Partition, portraying their bodies as sites of communal and patriarchal domination. In *Ice-Candy-Man*, the abduction and sexual violence faced by Ayah (Shanta), a Hindu woman, epitomize how women were treated as spoils of war. Sidhwa portrays Ayah's transformation from a confident, sensual figure into a silent victim of trauma to critique the objectification of women during the riots. The act of abducting and parading Ayah as a trophy illustrates how her body became a battleground for asserting communal superiority. The description – "They drag Ayah out. They drag her by her arms stretched taut, her bare feet dragging, leaving grooves in the dust..." (Sidhwa 123) portrays both the metaphorical assault of Ayah's dignity and the physical abuse she endured. Since women were deprived of agency in the face of community violence, her resistance is helpless against the mob's combined strength. As a poignant representation of erasure, the grooves her feet made in

the dust represent how the tragedy of Partition destroyed women's identities and humanity. The reader is made aware of the deep betrayal that Ayah perceives through Lenny's innocent yet perceptive viewpoint. Once the focus of love and respect for men from all communities and religions, Ayah now becomes the subject of their wrath. Lenny's perspective of the world changes after her kidnapping because she sees how friendship and love can turn into violence and hatred. Because Ayah is hurt by a group of people rather than just one guy, the act of hauling her away further emphasizes the communal aspect of the crime and illustrates how women were used as pieces in a broader game of retaliation and revenge between warring clans. This scene also emphasizes the complicity of spectators, particularly Lenny, who feels powerless and immobilized in the face of Ayah's pain. It reveals the societal systems that sustain gendered violence during times of war, in which the honour of a community or family is linked to the bodies of its women. Ayah's kidnapping is more than just a personal tragedy; it represents the larger institutional violence against women, in which they are reduced to symbols of shame, revenge, and control. In *What the Body Remembers*, Baldwin expands on gendered violence by exploring not only physical harm but also the psychological and emotional dimensions of patriarchal oppression. Satya, the first wife of Sardarji, experiences humiliation as her infertility renders her expendable. Her eventual death becomes a metaphor for the erasure of women's autonomy in a male-dominated society. Roop, the second wife, also confronts systemic violence, as her body is treated as a vessel for producing heirs. The violence in Baldwin's narrative is more insidious, revealing how patriarchy intertwines with communal politics to control women.

II. Agency and Resistance

Despite the overwhelming violence, both novels highlight moments of female agency and

resistance. In *Ice-Candy-Man*, Ayah's resilience is evident even in her victimization. Though her agency is constrained, her silence after the violence speaks volumes about her defiance against being reduced to a mere victim. Although Ayah is abducted and subjected to horrific violence, she shows remarkable strength and resilience. In the face of danger, she initially resists the mob's demands and tries to protect herself, demonstrating her courage even in the most desperate circumstances. Her survival, despite everything she endures, reflects her inner determination and challenges the idea that women during Partition were only passive victims. Instead, Ayah's story highlights her ability to endure and maintain her humanity in the midst of unimaginable trauma. Lenny, the young narrator, embodies a unique form of female agency. While she initially succumbs to pressure and reveals Ayah's hiding place, she experiences profound moral growth as the story progresses. Lenny begins to recognize and question the injustices she witnesses, taking on the role of an observer who documents the violence and highlights the strength of women like Ayah. By choosing to speak out later in the narrative, she challenges the societal tendency to remain silent about the suffering of women, asserting her own voice in the process. Sidhwa's portrayal of other female characters, such as Lenny's mother and Godmother, further emphasizes the strength of women in navigating a patriarchal society.

In contrast, *What the Body Remembers* gives a more nuanced exploration of agency through Satya and Roop. Satya, though constrained by infertility, asserts her power through her acerbic wit and control over the household. Her resistance to her husband's decision to remarry is a testament to her inner strength. Roop, on the other hand, evolves from a submissive bride to a woman who quietly asserts her individuality by reclaiming control over her children's future. Baldwin's narrative emphasizes that resistance can take various forms, from overt defiance to subtle acts of survival.

III. Intersections of Class, Religion, and Identity

Partition was not only a division of land but also a redefinition of identities along religious and class lines. It was a significant reshaping of societal structures, identities, and loyalties. The 1947 Partition of India, which led to the creation of India and Pakistan, was closely linked to religious and communal ideologies, triggering a dramatic change in how individuals perceived themselves and their relationship to others. Both novels explore how these intersections shaped women's experiences. In *Ice-Candy-Man*, Sidhwa contrasts the lives of Lenny, a privileged Parsi girl, with those of Ayah and other domestic workers who bear the brunt of Partition's violence. Ayah's vulnerability stems not only from her gender but also from her position as a lower-class Hindu woman in a predominantly Muslim Lahore. The novel critiques the complicity of the upper classes, who often turned a blind eye to the suffering of the marginalized.

Similarly, *What the Body Remembers* situates its narrative within the Sikh community, highlighting how women's roles were defined by their religious and social status. Roop's identity as a second wife reflects the intersection of class and gender, as her marriage is motivated by economic necessity rather than love. Baldwin's depiction of Sikh rituals and cultural practices further underscores how religion shaped women's lives during Partition. As the community becomes divided along religious lines, women are caught in the crossfire of these ideological battles:

"Hindu girls were being abducted, raped, forcibly converted... Muslims were being slaughtered and their homes burned down." (Baldwin 161) – This statement highlights the intersection of religion and violence during Partition, showing that women were not only victims of physical violence but also of religious ideologies that sought to subjugate them in the name of

honour, purity, or religious superiority.

IV. Memory, Trauma, and Healing

Both novels use memory as a narrative device to reconstruct the fragmented histories of Partition. In *Ice-Candy-Man*, Lenny's memories are fragmented and nonlinear, mirroring the chaos of Partition itself. Her childlike perspective allows Sidhwa to depict the incomprehensibility of violence while critiquing adult failures. The novel suggests that healing is possible only through the act of remembering and acknowledging past atrocities.

In *What the Body Remembers*, memory operates on both personal and generational levels. Roop's reflections on her life are interwoven with the collective trauma of the Sikh community. Baldwin emphasizes that healing requires not only confronting individual pain but also addressing the larger historical and cultural wounds of Partition.

Conclusion

Through our discussion, we come to the conclusion that both *Ice-Candy-Man* and *What the Body Remembers* offer profound insights into the gendered dimensions of Partition. By centering women's experiences, these novels challenge traditional historical narratives that marginalize feminine voices. Furthermore, their emphasis on landscapes and memory expands the scope of Partition literature, linking personal trauma to broader cultural and ecological themes. Together, they underscore the importance of reclaiming silenced histories, making them essential contributions to the understanding of Partition's legacy.

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